Netherbloom

Ralph Lauxie

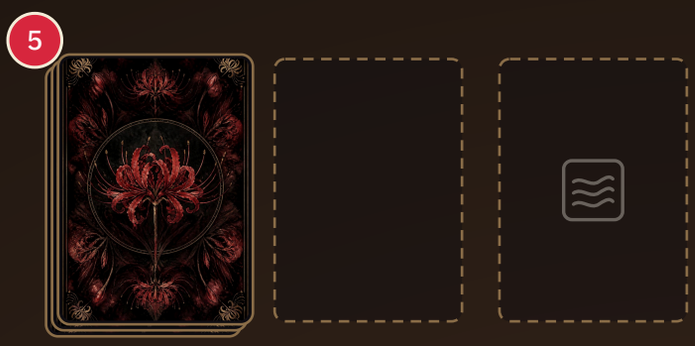
Rulebook

1–4 PLAYERS · 45–60 MIN · 14+

Setting up

The table set for the Child of the Last Flame with three Ferrymen. The numbers match the steps in section 5.

6 **Mist decks** One per Reach, face down beside it: its 10 Mist cards, Rising Water and Grievance Drawn Near, and harsh Mist cards by Lantern (0 / 2 / 3 / 3).

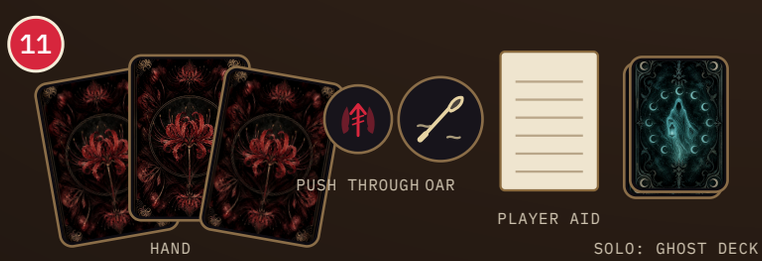


5 **Memory deck** 32 core cards and the Soul's own 8 (the 8 Echo cards for the Open Crossing), shuffled, face down. Discard pile face down; forgotten pile face up.

1 **River board** Three panels, joined edge to edge: Reach I on the left (the near shore, space 0) to Reach III on the right (the Far Shore, space 12).

3 **First Blooms and the soul** A Bloom on both banks of space 1, so the first step is Lit. The soul token starts on the near shore, space 0.

7 **Loom of the Fates** The Loom board, knot discs beside it. Each knot goes on its thread's next circle: a thread snaps at 4 knots with 2–3 players, at 5 in solo or with 4. The Echo token waits beside the board.



11 **Ferrymen** Deal 3 cards each (4 in solo play). Each player takes a Push Through token face up and a Player Aid. The first player takes the Oar. Solo: the 12 Ghost cards are the Ghost's deck.

4

FRACTURES 3 LIGHT

4 Soul card and Lantern The chosen Soul card, face up. Fractures go beside it: the third shatters the soul. The Child starts with 3 Light. The Lantern is the difficulty you choose (section 21); it has no piece.

9

9 Book of Remembrance The chosen Soul's Book, open at Chapter I. Inscribed cards go in its wells, held by the photo corners.

REACH III

2 Bank cards 6 / 8 / 6 cards for Reaches I / II / III. Shuffle each Reach's cards apart and lay them fog side up in the wells of spaces 2–4, 5–8 and 9–11.

8

8 Mantles The 4 Mantle cards, face up, where everyone can reach them.

10

ROOT / BLOOM × 24	GRIEVANCE × 8	BLACK WATER × 6
LIGHT × 12	FRACTURE × 3	KNOT × 15
HOLD FAST × 1	SHIELD × 1	RESIGNATION × 1

10 Supply Every token within reach. Black Water: take only the Lantern's number (6 / 6 / 4 / 3 for Gentle / Standard / Hard / Heroic) and put the rest back in the box.

1. Prologue: the river of forgetting

Whoever drinks from the River Lethe forgets.

Below the world of the living runs a black river. The dead must cross it to reach the **Far Shore**, where a veiled **Keeper** waits with one cup of river water. Drink it, and the weight of a whole life slips away.

An old ferryman carries the dead across, but only those who were buried with a coin for the fare. The others, the **coinless dead**, wake alone on the **near shore** and wander the bank. Fog fills them, and they begin to forget: first the small things, then the faces, then their own names. A soul that forgets everything simply fades into the mist.

You are the **Ferrymen**: servants of the underworld, neither living nor dead. The coinless the old ferryman will not carry are given to you. You have no boat. You have something stranger. Along the banks of Lethe grows the **Netherbloom**, a crimson flower of long, curling petals, blooming on a bare stalk with no leaves, because *flower and leaf never meet*. Its glow is the only light in the fog that a lost soul can follow. Where you plant Netherblooms, a soul can walk.

One more thing: the servants of the river are bound to silence. No Ferryman may speak on the water, not to the dead and not to one another. Whatever you mean to say to each other, you must say with the flowers you plant and the choices you make.

2. Your mission

Carry one soul to the Far Shore, and help it remember who it was.

Every game, one soul wakes on the near shore. You share two tasks, and you succeed or fail together:

1. **The crossing.** Light a path of Netherblooms across the three Reaches of the river and bring the soul to the Far Shore at space 12. That is how you **win**.
2. **The remembering.** The soul's memories are the cards in your hands. As you play them, the best of them can be **inscribed** in the **Book of Remembrance**, a sentence at a time. What you write decides *how* the soul meets the Keeper, and the Book is read aloud when the crossing ends.

The river fights back in three ways, and each is a way to lose:

- **Faded**: the soul forgets too much and dissolves into the mist.
- **Shattered**: grief breaks the soul three times.
- **Deluge**: the black water rises with nothing left to hold it back.

The tension at the heart of the game: forgetting is both a weapon and a wound. Letting memories go makes the soul lighter and faster, and some of your strongest cards are acts of forgetting. But every memory you let go is gone from the soul's story, and brings it closer to fading.

3. The Rule of Silence

The servants of the river serve in silence. Your only language is the last card played.

From setup until the soul reaches the Far Shore or is lost, nobody speaks about the game. Do not name or show the cards in your hand, hint at them, point, or ask others what to play.

You may talk about what everyone can already see: the river, the Loom, the Book. Your real voice is the **Echo**, the thread of the last card played face up or Burned (section 13). Following someone's Echo says **"I understood you"**. Leaving a clear Echo says **"this is what I need next"**.

When the game ends, the silence lifts. One of you reads the Book aloud, page by page, and the table finally hears the life it saved together.

4. The world on your table

Every piece on the table is part of the story.

What each piece is in the story, and what it does in play. The icons are the same ones you see on the board and the cards.

Piece	In the story	In play
The soul	A coinless dead person, waking on the near shore with a whole life still inside them.	The pawn you escort from space 0 to the Far Shore at space 12. It only steps onto Lit spaces.
The river	The River Lethe, winding from the near shore to the Far Shore.	Spaces 0 to 12. Spaces 1-11 each have a left and a right bank, and each bank holds one tile or token.
The three Reaches	Three stretches of the underworld: the grey **Asphodel Road**, the **Fields of Mourning** where grief lingers, and the **Banks of Lethe** where the water is deepest.	Spaces 1-4, 5-8 and 9-11. Each Reach has its own Mist deck and its own chapter in the Book. The Loom is cleared as the soul enters each one.
The Far Shore	Where the veiled Keeper waits with the cup of forgetting.	Space 12. When the soul reaches it, you win.
Fog	The mist that hides the bank. Nobody knows what lies under it.	Covers each bank until a Root is placed there and reveals the tile below.
Fertile ground	Soft riverbank earth.	A Root takes here.
Stony ground	Hard, grey stone where little can grow.	An ordinary Root is lost. Only stubborn Roots and the Root-Weaver grow here.
Memory Site	A place the soul once knew, surfacing through the fog.	The Root takes and you find a **keepsake**, a small object from the soul's life. In the Open Crossing it also gives 2 Light.
Grave	A grave on the bank. Something unfinished is buried here.	No Root grows. A Grievance rises instead.
Root	A Netherbloom seed, planted in the dark.	Extends your network. It does not light a space by itself.
Bloom	An open Netherbloom, glowing crimson. The only light a lost soul can follow.	A space with a Bloom on either bank is **Lit**, and the soul can step onto it.
Light	The glow of the flowers the soul has passed, gathered and carried.	Each Bloom the soul leaves behind gives 1 Light. Spend Light to summon Mantles or to Recall a forgotten card.

Piece	In the story	In play
Memory cards	The soul's memories. Your hands together are what the soul still remembers.	Two actions a turn: play a card, Seek, Recall, or Push Through. Each card carries an effect, a thread, and often a line of the soul's life.
Obsession thread	The thread that is spun and held: clinging, grudges, things the soul cannot let go.	Strong Root cards. A full thread snaps into **Grasping**: a Grievance appears beside the soul.
Acceptance thread	The thread that is measured: tenderness, forgiveness, peace.	Bloom and Mend cards. A full thread snaps into **Resignation**: the soul sits down and Lingers.
Oblivion thread	The thread that is cut: deliberate forgetting.	Powerful cards that clear the way, but are forgotten after use. A full thread snaps into **the Tide Rises**: Black Water floods ahead.
The Loom of the Fates	The great loom where the three Fates weave every soul's last journey.	Each card played face up ties a knot on its thread. Too many knots on one thread cause a Backlash.
The Echo	The shuttle of the Loom, resting on the last thread you pulled. In a silent world it is your voice.	The thread of the last card played face up or Burned. If your first card matches it, the card **Resonates**.
Grievance	A restless shade of the soul's own unfinished resentment.	Blocks a bank. Beside the soul, it feeds: 1 Fracture each Soul Step. If two block the space ahead, a player can spend an action to push the soul through them, at a cost.
Black Water	The river rising to swallow the path.	Floods a space so the soul cannot enter, and withers its Blooms. The supply is limited; when water must rise and none is left, it is a Deluge.
Fracture	A crack in the soul's sense of self.	The third Fracture shatters the soul.
Forgotten pile	Everything the river has taken.	Forgotten cards are gone unless Light Recalls one. Enough of them make the soul lighter (Light as Ash), then reckless (Adrift), then Faded.
Mist cards	The underworld itself: rising water, cold wind, returning fog.	One is turned at the end of every turn, from the deck of the current Reach.
Mantles	Roles a Ferryman can take up on the river: the Root-Weaver, the Spirit Warden, the Bloom-Bringer, the Fog-Breaker.	Summon one with Light for a permanent power (section 17).
The Lantern	How dark the river is tonight.	The difficulty: Gentle, Standard, Hard or Heroic.
Book of Remembrance	The spring of Memory the old grave-texts told the dead to seek instead of Lethe. What is written here, the soul keeps.	Three pages, one per Reach, each a sentence with four blanks. Resonating cards fill them.
Place · Person · Deed · Feeling	The four parts of a remembered moment: where, who, what was done, and what it left behind.	The four slots on each page of the Book. Each memory card fits one of them.
Key Memory	The one memory that matters most to this soul.	Can be inscribed whenever it is played face up. Whether it is written, forgotten or never spoken decides the ending.

Piece	In the story	In play
The Ghost (solo)	A silent Ferryman who travels beside you.	In solo play it plays a card after each of your turns and leaves the Echo for you to follow.
The Oar	The ferry's oar, passed from hand to hand in silence.	Whoever holds the Oar is taking their turn. Pass it to the left after you draw. In solo play, lay it on the Ghost's deck: the Ghost plays next.
Push Through tokens	A Ferryman's one hard shove against the shades.	Each player takes one at setup and turns it face down when they Push Through. The face-down tokens count the pushes made, which sets the price of the next one.
Hold Fast token	An anchor let down beside the soul.	Put beside the soul when *Hold Fast* is played: if the soul Lingers, it forgets nothing. Remove it when the next turn begins.
Shield token	A Ferryman standing between the soul and harm.	Put in front of the player who plays *Hold the Line*. It stops the next Fracture and is removed, or is removed when that player's next turn ends. If *Hold the Line* is played again, the token moves to the new player.
Resignation token	The soul, sitting down among the reeds.	Put beside the soul when the Acceptance thread snaps. At the next Soul Step the soul Lingers; then remove it.

Cards that keep count. Some powers need no token. Turn the **Spirit Warden** sideways when it is used and straighten it at the start of its holder's turn. Turn a Soul card sideways when its once-only twist is spent (section 19). A solo player turns a laid-down Mantle face down (section 17).

5. Setting up

Before the first step, the Ferrymen lay out the river in silence.

The picture on pages 2 and 3 shows the table set up for the Child of the Last Flame. Its numbers match the steps below.

1. **The river board.** Join the three panels in order: Reach I on the left, where the near shore is, and Reach III on the right, ending at the Far Shore.
2. **Bank cards.** Sort the bank cards by the Reach printed on their fog side: 6, 8, 6 cards for Reaches I, II and III. Shuffle each Reach's cards on their own and lay them **fog side up** in the wells of spaces 2-4, 5-8 and 9-11. Nobody looks underneath.
3. **The first Blooms and the soul.** Space 1 has no bank cards: put a Bloom on both of its banks, so the first step is always Lit. Put the soul token on the near shore (space 0).
4. **The Soul and the Lantern.** Choose a Soul (section 19) and a Lantern (section 21). Lay the Soul card face up beside the board and leave room next to it for Fracture tokens. The Child of the Last Flame starts with **3 Light**; every other Soul starts with none.
5. **The Memory deck.** Shuffle the 32 core Memory cards with the Soul's own 8-card pack (the 8 Echo cards for the Open Crossing) and put the deck face down. Leave room beside it for the **discard pile** (face down) and the **forgotten pile** (face up).

6. **The Mist decks.** Build one deck for each Reach: its 10 Mist cards, plus one *Rising Water* and one *Grievance Drawn Near*, plus the Lantern's number of harsh Mist cards drawn at random (none at Gentle). Shuffle each deck and put it face down beside its Reach.
7. **The Loom of the Fates.** Lay out the Loom board with its three threads, Obsession, Acceptance and Oblivion, and put the knot discs beside it. Each knot goes on its thread's next circle. A thread holds 4 knots with 2-3 players and 5 in solo play or with 4. Keep the Echo token ready: there is no Echo until the first card is played face up or Burned.
8. **The Mantles.** Lay the four Mantle cards face up where everyone can reach them.
9. **The Book of Remembrance.** Open the chosen Soul's Book at Chapter I, with the photo corners to hand for inscribing.
10. **The supply.** Put the Root/Bloom discs, Grievances, Light, Fractures, knots and the Hold Fast, Shield and Resignation tokens within reach. Of the Black Water, take only the Lantern's number (6, 6, 4, 3 for Gentle, Standard, Hard, Heroic) and put the rest back in the box.
11. **The Ferrymen.** Deal each player a hand: 4 cards in solo play, 3 with 2-4 players. Each player takes a Push Through token, face up. The first player takes the **Oar**. In solo play, shuffle the 12 Ghost cards into the Ghost's deck beside you.

Then the silence begins (section 3), and the first player takes the first turn.

6. How a crossing unfolds

Three Reaches, three chapters of a life, and one cup at the end.

A game is a single crossing of about 15 turns. As the soul walks each Reach, the Book of Remembrance fills one chapter of its life:

- **Reach I, the Asphodel Road: Chapter I, Who I Was.** Where the soul was born, who it loved, what it carried.
- **Reach II, the Fields of Mourning: Chapter II, What I Did.** The deed that defined it, and its price.
- **Reach III, the Banks of Lethe: Chapter III, What I Carry.** What it forgives, what it cannot undo, what it keeps.

Each Reach is harder than the last: the Mist grows crueler and the soul has forgotten more. At the Far Shore, the Keeper offers the cup, and the soul's Key Memory decides how it is received (section 24).

7. The river

The river winds from the near shore to the Far Shore, and every bank is a place a flower might grow.

The river has 13 spaces: the near shore (0), spaces 1 to 11, and the Far Shore (12). Each space from 1 to 11 has a **left** and a **right bank**, and each bank holds one token. Banks are named as you face downstream toward the Far Shore: the left bank is the row above the river, the right bank the row below.

- **Reach I, the Asphodel Road**: spaces 1-4.
- **Reach II, the Fields of Mourning**: spaces 5-8.
- **Reach III, the Banks of Lethe**: spaces 9-11.

Each Reach has its own Mist deck and its own page in the Book of Remembrance. When the soul enters a new Reach, the Loom of the Fates is cleared.

At setup both banks of space 1 hold a Bloom, so the first step is always lit. The banks of spaces 2-11 are hidden under **fog** tiles.

8. Roots, Blooms and the network

A Netherbloom grows only from another. Your path must be one unbroken thread of light.

A **Root** is a seed in the dark. A **Bloom** is a Root that has opened into a Netherbloom.

A space is **Lit** when at least one of its banks holds a Bloom. The soul only steps onto a Lit space.

Placing a Root. A Root goes on an empty bank at or ahead of the soul that **touches the network**:

- it is on the soul's own space or the next one, or
- the opposite bank of the same space holds a token, or
- the same bank of the space before or after holds a token.

Blooming turns one of your Roots, at or ahead of the soul, into a Bloom.

9. Fog and tiles

Under the fog lie soft earth, hard stone, half-remembered places and old graves.

Fog hides each bank. Placing a Root on fog reveals the tile beneath, and the tile decides what happens:

- **Fertile**: the Root takes.
- **Stony**: an ordinary Root will not take, and the Root is lost. Stubborn Roots and the Root-Weaver can grow here.
- **Memory Site**: the Root takes and you find a keepsake. In the Open Crossing it also gives +2 Light.
- **Grave**: no Root grows, and a Grievance rises on that bank.

Reach I has 3 Fertile, 1 Stony and 2 Memory Site tiles. Reach II has 3 Fertile, 2 Stony, 2 Memory Site and 1 Grave. Reach III has 2 Fertile, 1 Stony, 2 Memory Site and 1 Grave. The Mist can roll fog back over empty revealed ground.

10. Your turn

You plant, the soul walks, the river answers.

1. **Summon a Mantle** (optional, before your Answer).
2. **The Answer** (your first action): play a card face up, face down or Burned, **Seek**, **Recall** a forgotten card with 3 Light, or **Push Through** if Grievances hold both banks ahead.
3. **The Steer** (your second action): the same choices except Recall (and only one Seek a turn, and each Ferryman may Push Through only once per game).

4. **Bloom-Bringer**: if you hold this Mantle, Bloom one Root for free.
5. **Soul Step**: the soul moves or Lingers.
6. **The Mist**: turn the top card of the current Reach's Mist deck.
7. **The river settles**: roots drink the flood, and trapped Grievances dissolve.
8. **Draw** back up to your hand size and pass the **Oar** to the left. In solo play, the Ghost now takes its turn.

Hand size is 4 in solo play and 3 with 2-4 players. Everything that happens after your two actions, step by step, is in section 11.

11. The end of the turn: how the river answers

When the second action is done, the Ferrymen lift their hands from the river, and the river answers.

The river answers at the end of **every turn**, after each player's two actions, not once a round: with three players it answers three times before the first player's next turn. Work through these steps in order.

1. **The Bloom-Bringer.** If the player whose turn it is holds the Bloom-Bringer, they may Bloom one Root at or ahead of the soul, free.
2. **The Soul Step** (section 15). Go down this list and stop at the first line that applies:
   a. **Resignation token beside the soul?** It sits down and Lingers: forget the top card of the deck (nothing prevents it), then remove the token. Go to *e*.
   b. **Is the next space Lit and not flooded?** The soul steps onto it. **Take the Light:** 1 Light for each Bloom on the space it leaves. Then clear that space: its Blooms, Roots and Grievances go back to the supply. If the soul enters a new Reach, clear the Loom (the Echo stays where it is) and straighten the Child's Soul card.
   c. **Extra steps.** If 9 or more cards are forgotten (**Adrift**), the soul steps once more; if that space is dark it drifts in anyway and takes 1 Fracture, unless an upright Spirit Warden holds it back (turn the Warden sideways). Otherwise, if 6 or more are forgotten (**Light as Ash**), it steps once more, but only onto a Lit, dry space. Each extra step takes the Light behind it too.
   d. **It cannot step: it Lingers.** Check in order. The Hold Fast token is beside it: it waits and forgets nothing. The Spirit Warden is upright: turn it sideways; the soul waits. Its own space is Lit: it waits beside its light. The Bride, once a game: she is pulled back one space instead (turn her Soul card sideways). Otherwise: **forget the top card of the deck**.
   e. **Feeding.** If a Grievance stands on either bank of the soul's space, it feeds: **1 Fracture**.
3. **The Mist** (section 20). Turn the top card of the Mist deck of the Reach the soul is now in, and do what it says, measured from where the soul stands. If that deck is empty, shuffle that Reach's 10 basic Mist cards into a new deck first.
4. **The river settles** (section 16).
   - Each flooded space with a Root or Bloom on **both** banks: the roots drink the flood. Remove the Black Water from the game.
   - Each Grievance with a Bloom on the same bank in the space before it **and** the space after it is trapped in light: it dissolves.
5. **Draw** back up to your hand size. If the deck runs out, shuffle the discard pile into a new deck and go on drawing.

6. **Solo: the Ghost.** Turn the top Ghost card. Do its action, tie a knot on its thread (a full thread Backlashes) and move the Echo to that thread. Then the river settles again (step 4). When the Ghost deck runs out, shuffle all the Ghost cards into a new one.
7. **Pass the Oar** to the left. In solo play it comes back to you after the Ghost.

As the next turn begins

- Remove the **Hold Fast** token if it is out.
- If you hold the **Spirit Warden**, straighten it at the start of your own turn.
- A **Shield** that has not stopped a Fracture is removed when the player who raised it ends their next turn.

Whenever it happens

Some things never wait for a step. A thread that fills **Backlashes** at once; a page that reaches its count brings its **Chapter Blessing** at once; a revealed Memory Site gives its **keepsake** at once. And the game ends the moment the soul reaches the Far Shore (you win), the forgotten pile reaches the Lantern's limit (**Faded**), the third Fracture is taken (**Shattered**), or Black Water must rise with none left in the supply (**Deluge**). A Fracture stopped by a Shield or the Child's flame is not taken.

12. Your two actions: three ways to play a card, Seek, Recall, or Push Through

A memory can be spoken, kept quiet, or burned away for strength. Or you can let one go and reach for another.

Each turn you take **two actions**, one at a time. The first is your **Answer**: it is the only one that can answer the Echo. The second is your **Steer**, your hand on the tiller once the Echo is behind you. Each action is to play a card from your hand in one of three ways, to Seek, to Recall (Answer only), or to Push Through.

- **Face up** (spoken): do the card's effect, tie one knot on its thread in the Loom, and the card's thread becomes the new **Echo**. Obsession and Acceptance cards go to the discard pile. **Oblivion** cards are **forgotten** after use.
- **Face down** (kept quiet): place 1 Root. No knot is tied and the Echo does not change. The card is discarded.
- **Burn** (burned away): do the effect **twice**, tie a knot, and its thread becomes the new **Echo** (a Burned first card can Resonate). Then the card is forgotten, along with the top card of the deck. The soul grows lighter, and its story grows shorter.

Seek (once per turn): discard a card from your hand and draw one. Nothing is played, no knot is tied and the Echo does not change. Only your **Answer** can Resonate, so if you Seek as your Answer you let the Echo pass this turn; Seek as your Steer and your first card has already had its chance. Seek when your hand holds nothing the river needs.

Recall (your Answer only): spend **3 Light** and choose any one card from the forgotten pile; it is remembered and goes to the discard pile, so it can come back into the deck. Nothing is played, no knot is tied and the Echo does not change. Recall takes your Answer, so the Echo passes this turn. A forgotten Key Memory can be brought back this way.

Push Through (each Ferryman only **once per game**, and only when Grievances hold both banks of the space ahead of the soul): drive the soul through them now, at a price, and turn your Push Through token face down. It uses no card; see section 15. Like a Seek, a Push Through taken as your Answer lets the Echo pass.

The **discard pile** is face down. Every card goes onto it face down, even one played face up, and nobody looks through it. The **forgotten pile** is face up, so anyone may check what the river has taken.

13. The Echo and Resonance

When two silent Ferrymen pull the same thread, the Loom sings.

The **Echo** is the thread of the last card played face up or Burned, by anyone. It is how silent players talk.

If the **first** card you play on your turn is on the Echo's thread, it **Resonates**. Do its Resonance effect as well; some Oblivion cards do their Resonance *instead*. A Resonating card that carries a memory may be **inscribed** in the Book of Remembrance.

Only your Answer (your first action) can Resonate. If your Answer is a Seek, a Recall or a Push Through, the Echo passes unanswered this turn.

Leaving an Echo the next player can safely follow is the heart of the game.

14. The Loom of the Fates and Backlash

Pull one thread too hard and the Fates pull back.

The Loom has three threads: **Obsession**, **Acceptance** and **Oblivion**. Every card played face up or Burned ties a knot on its thread. A thread holds 4 knots with 2-3 players and 5 in solo play or with 4 players.

When a thread fills, it snaps in a **Backlash** and empties:

- **Obsession, Grasping**: the soul clutches its grudges, and a Grievance appears beside it.
- **Acceptance, Resignation**: the soul gives up for a moment. Put the Resignation token beside it: at the next Soul Step it sits down and Lingers, forgetting a card, and the token is removed.
- **Oblivion, the Tide Rises**: too much has been let go, and Black Water floods the space ahead.

The Loom clears whenever the soul enters a new Reach.

15. The Soul Step

The soul walks only toward light. In the dark, it waits, and waiting, it forgets.

After your actions the soul tries to step forward. If the next space is **Lit and not flooded**, it moves there. It gains 1 Light for each Bloom it leaves behind, and the space it left is cleared, so each Bloom gives its Light only once (section 17).

Otherwise it **Lingers**. Beside its own light (its own space is Lit) it simply waits. In the dark it forgets the top card of the deck. *Hold Fast* (its token beside the soul) and the Spirit Warden stop a Linger.

Through the shades. If Grievances hold **both** banks of the next space, the way is shut and the soul will Linger. On your turn you may spend an action to **Push Through** (each Ferryman only once per game, and only if that space is not flooded): both Grievances scatter, the soul steps onto the space at once, and it pays dearly, taking **1 Fracture**

and forgetting the top card of the deck. Each push already made this game (count the face-down Push Through tokens) costs **one more Fracture**: the second push costs 2, the third 3, which shatters the soul. The Soul Step still follows as usual. Push once; after that, clear the way with your cards.

Light as Ash. Once 6 cards are forgotten, the soul glides one extra space whenever it can. It has less to carry.

Adrift. Once 9 cards are forgotten, each time the soul moves it moves one more space. If that space is dark it drifts in anyway and suffers a Fracture (the Spirit Warden can hold it back). It has almost nothing left to hold it in place.

If a Grievance sits beside the soul after the step, it feeds: **1 Fracture**.

16. Black Water, Grievances and Fractures

The river rises, old resentments crawl out of the graves, and the soul begins to crack.

≋ **Black Water** floods a whole space. The soul cannot step onto it, and Blooms on it wither to Roots. When both banks of a flooded space hold a Root or Bloom at the end of a turn, the roots **drink the flood** and it drains. Drained water leaves the game, so the supply only shrinks. If water must rise and the supply is empty: **Deluge**.

A **Grievance** takes a bank and blocks it. One beside the soul feeds on it each Soul Step. A Grievance with a Bloom on the same bank both before and after it is **trapped in light** and dissolves at the end of the turn. If Grievances hold both banks of the space ahead, the soul cannot pass, unless a player spends an action to Push Through them (section 15).

Fractures come from feeding Grievances, pushing through the shades, Adrift, and the Dark Wind. At 3 the soul is **Shattered**. *Hold the Line* raises a Shield that stops the next Fracture: put the Shield token in front of you until it is used or your next turn ends.

17. Mantles and Light

The light of passed flowers can be spent to take up an old role of the river, or to call back what the river took.

Light is gathered from the Blooms the soul leaves behind. There are two ways to spend it:

- **Summon a Mantle** before your Answer: pay Light (3, or 2 for the King) and discard a card of the Mantle's thread. With 2-4 players each player holds at most one Mantle, and keeps it for the game.
- **Recall** as your Answer: pay 3 Light to bring one forgotten card of your choice back to the discard pile (section 12).

When Light is gathered. Light is taken only when the soul **steps off** a space: 1 Light for each Bloom on that space, once. The space is then cleared, so a Bloom gives its Light a single time; flowers still ahead of the soul give nothing until the soul walks past them. Light is **not** collected at the end of a round. Once taken, Light stays in your shared pool from turn to turn until you spend it (a Mantle or a Recall) or the Dark Wind blows 2 of it out. The Open Crossing also gains 2 Light from each Memory Site revealed, and the Child of the Last Flame starts with 3.

Solo: trading Mantles. In solo play you may summon a new Mantle even while you hold one. The Mantle you held is **laid down for good**: turn its card face down, and no one can summon it again. Each Mantle can be summoned only once, and you may summon at most 3 times in a game, so one Mantle always stays out of reach. On each turn you choose how to spend your Light: a new Mantle, a Recall, or saving it.

- **The Root-Weaver**: Your Roots may grow on Stony ground. Your first Root effect each turn places 1 extra Root.
- **The Spirit Warden**: Once per round, stop the soul from Lingering or from drifting Adrift.
- **The Bloom-Bringer**: At the end of each of your turns, Bloom 1 Root for free.
- **The Fog-Breaker**: Your first Oblivion card each turn is discarded instead of forgotten.

The Spirit Warden acts on other players' turns too, so turn its card sideways when it is used and straighten it at the start of its holder's turn.

18. The Book of Remembrance

The old grave-texts told the dead: do not drink from Lethe; find the spring of Memory. This Book is that spring.

The Book has one page per Reach. Each page has four slots, **Place**, **Person**, **Deed** and **Feeling**, which fill a sentence about the soul's life.

You may **inscribe** a card when it Resonates, if its memory's slot is still empty on the current page. A **Key Memory** card may be inscribed whenever it is played face up. An inscribed card leaves the deck for good: you trade a useful card for a memory the soul will keep.

Chapter Blessing. When a page holds 3 memories (2 for the Garland Girl), the river grants the first of these that applies: mend a Fracture, drain Black Water, or return a forgotten card.

At the end, the Book is read aloud. Slots never filled read "...but this, the river has taken".

19. The Souls

Four souls the old ferryman would not carry, and one with no name at all.

Each named Soul adds its own 8-card pack of memories, including one **Key Memory**, and a twist to the rules that comes from its story. The Open Crossing adds the 8 Echo cards instead.

Child of the Last Flame

A small child alone in a doorway on the coldest night of the year, with a handful of little lights to sell and none sold. To keep warm she lights them one by one, and in each flame she sees something: a warm stove, a feast, and at last the one person who ever held her, coming to take her home.

Twist: Starts with 3 Light. The first Fracture in each Reach is ignored. Never drifts Adrift. She can forget 1 more card before she Fades. No harsh Mist. Her small flames protect her. Turn her Soul card sideways when the flame is spent, and straighten it as the soul enters a new Reach. **Key Memory:** *the one who used to hold me before she was gone.*

The Garland Girl

A young woman who wove a flower for everyone she loved. Her father died, the man who promised to marry her turned cruel, and she gave her flowers away one by one and slipped into a brook still singing. She kept one flower for herself, and no one ever learned which.

Twist: The Chapter Blessing comes after only 2 inscribed memories. She is the Soul of the Book. **Key Memory:** *the one flower I kept for myself.*

The King on the Barge

An old king who won every battle but the last. His closest friend loved his queen, his fellowship broke apart, and he fell on a field of his own making. Dying, he was laid on a black barge. The sword he was lent was never returned to the water it came from, and so he cannot rest.

Twist: Mantles cost 2 Light. A Fracture strips the Mantle of the player who caused it. His companions rally cheaply, and fall away when things break. **Key Memory:** *the hand that rose from the lake to give me a sword.*

The Bride Who Stayed Below

She died on her wedding day. Her husband came down into the dark to bring her back, on one condition: he must not look back until they reached the light. One step from the surface, he turned. She has stood in the shadows ever since, deciding whether to remember his face or let it go.

Twist: The first time she would Linger in the dark, she is pulled one space back instead of forgetting. Turn her Soul card sideways once she has been pulled back. **Key Memory:** *his face, the instant he turned to look at me.*

Open Crossing

A nameless soul. You do not learn its story; you write it. Memory Sites give +2 Light. There is no Key Memory, so the Book is all the soul will have.

> **Your first crossing:** we suggest **Child of the Last Flame** at the Gentle Lantern. Its twists let a new table learn the river, the Loom and the Book before meeting the other Souls.

20. The Mist

The underworld is not empty. After every turn, it moves.

At the end of every turn the top card of the current Reach's Mist deck is turned. Each deck also holds 2 extra cards (Rising Water and Grievance Drawn Near) and, at every Lantern except Gentle, some **harsh** cards.

Mist card	Reach	What happens
Rising Water	I, II, III	Black Water floods the river ahead.
Grievance	I, II	A Grievance takes a bank ahead.
Grievance Drawn Near	I, II, III	A Grievance settles beside the soul.
Withering	I, II, III	The 2 furthest Blooms ahead wither to Roots.
Fog Returns	I, II	Fog rolls back over empty ground.
Cold Wind	I, II, III	A memory is forgotten.
The Mist Parts	I	Nothing stirs. Breathe.
Echo Severed	II, III	The Echo is torn from the Loom.
Undertow	III	Water rises and the Blooms beside it wither.
Twin Grievances	III	Two Grievances take the banks ahead.
Great Withering	III	Three Blooms ahead wither to Roots.

Mist card	Reach	What happens
Bitter Wind	III	Two memories are forgotten.
Flood Surge	Harsh	Black Water floods twice.
Grievance Host	Harsh	Grievances crowd both banks ahead.
Wither Storm	Harsh	Every Bloom beyond the next two spaces withers.
Deep Cold	Harsh	Two memories are forgotten.
Karma Surge	Harsh	A knot is tied on every thread.
Dark Wind	Harsh	Lose 2 Light, or suffer a Fracture.

21. Lantern levels

The darker the night, the less a lantern shows.

The Lantern sets the difficulty. **Standard** is the game as designed: a good table wins about half its crossings. **Gentle** is for learning, **Hard** for tables that have crossed often, and **Heroic** for those who want the river at its darkest.

Lantern	Black Water supply	Faded at	Harsh Mist per Reach
◆◇◇◇ Gentle	6	14 forgotten	0
◆◆◇◇ Standard	6	11 forgotten	2
◆◆◆◇ Hard	4	10 forgotten	3
◆◆◆◆ Heroic	3	9 forgotten	3

22. Solo play and the Ghost

Even a lone Ferryman is never quite alone on the river.

In solo play you hold 4 cards, each Loom thread holds 5 knots, and after each of your turns the **Ghost** plays the top card of its own deck. The Ghost ties a knot and sets the Echo, so plan around it.

With no one to share the Mantles, you may **trade your Mantle** for a new one (section 17): the old one is laid down for good, and you have 3 summons in all. You may also spend Light on a **Recall**, like any Ferryman.

Ghost card	×	Action
Obsession	3	Roots on the furthest open bank
Obsession	2	Roots on the nearest open bank
Acceptance	2	Blooms the nearest Root
Acceptance	2	Blooms the furthest Root
Oblivion	2	Banishes the nearest Grievance, or drains Black Water
Oblivion	1	Does nothing

23. Winning and losing

Win: the soul reaches the Far Shore.

- **Faded**: the forgotten pile reaches the Lantern's limit. So much was forgotten that nothing was left to cross.
- **Shattered**: the third Fracture. Broken three times, the soul could carry itself no further.
- **Deluge**: Black Water must rise but the supply is empty. The black river rose, and nothing was left to hold it back.

24. The Far Shore and the cup

At the Far Shore the Keeper lifts the veil and offers the cup. What the soul remembers decides how it drinks.

When the crossing ends, the silence lifts. Look at where the soul's **Key Memory** is:

- **Inscribed in the Book**: kept and spoken. The soul crosses remembering what mattered most.
- **Forgotten**: lost to the river. The soul goes on, lighter and emptier, without it.
- **Never written** (still in the deck, a hand or the discard pile): never faced. Some things go across unsaid.

Then read the Book aloud, page by page. Even a lost crossing leaves a story: blanks read "...but this, the river has taken", and the epilogue tells how the soul was lost. Every game writes a different life.

25. Card reference

Card	Face up	Resonance
Deep Roots	Place 2 Roots.	Place 1 Root.
Echo card `Open Crossing`	Place 2 Roots.	Place 1 Root.
Echo card `Open Crossing`	The soul waits without forgetting this turn.	Place 1 Root.
Echo card `Open Crossing`	Read the top 3 Mist cards and put the worst of them last.	Place 1 Root.
Hold Fast	The soul waits without forgetting this turn.	Place 1 Root.
Hold the Line	Prevent the next Fracture before your next turn.	Place 1 Root.
Old Oath	Gain 2 Light.	Gain 1 Light.
Overreach	Place 3 Roots. Tie 1 extra Obsession knot.	Bloom 1 Root.
Stubborn Root	Place 1 Root, even on Stony ground.	Place 1 Root, even on Stony ground.
Vigil	Read the top 3 Mist cards and put the worst of them last.	Place 1 Root.
Echo card `Open Crossing`	Bloom 1 Root. Place 1 Root.	Bloom 1 Root.

Card	Face up	Resonance
❀ **Echo card** `Open Crossing`	Bloom 2 Roots.	Gain 1 Light.
❀ **Echo card** `Open Crossing`	Mend 1 Fracture.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **Full Bloom**	Bloom 2 Roots.	Gain 1 Light.
❀ **Guide**	The soul steps forward now, if the next space is Lit.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **Held** `Key Memory`	Mend 1 Fracture.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **His Face** `Key Memory`	The soul steps forward now, if the next space is Lit.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **Let Go**	Untie 2 knots on the fullest thread.	Untie 1 knot on the fullest thread.
❀ **Mend**	Mend 1 Fracture.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **One Flower Kept** `Key Memory`	Bloom 1 Root. Gain 1 Light.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **Open Hand**	Bloom 1 Root. Place 1 Root.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **Rekindle**	Bloom 1 Root. Gain 1 Light.	Bloom 1 Root.
❀ **The Lake's Gift** `Key Memory`	Bloom 1 Root. Place 1 Root.	Bloom 1 Root.
○ **Blank Fog**	Lift the fog across this Reach; Graves turn Fertile.	Gain 2 Light.
○ **Echo card** `Open Crossing`	Banish the nearest Grievance or drain the nearest Black Water.	Instead: Banish the nearest Grievance. Drain the nearest Black Water.
○ **Echo card** `Open Crossing`	Gain 3 Light.	Bloom 1 Root.
○ **Lethe's Gift**	Gain 3 Light.	Bloom 1 Root.
○ **Low Tide**	Drain all Black Water in this Reach.	Banish the nearest Grievance.
○ **Unmake**	Empty the fullest thread with no Backlash.	Gain 1 Light.
○ **Unremember**	Banish the nearest Grievance or drain the nearest Black Water.	Instead: Banish the nearest Grievance. Drain the nearest Black Water.
○ **Wash Away**	Wash away the Grievances beside the soul.	Gain 1 Light.

Player Aid

On your turn

1. **Summon**
   optional · pay Light, discard a matching card. Solo: you may trade your Mantle for a new one (the old is laid down for good), 3 summons a game
2. **Answer**
   your first action: a card that matches the Echo Resonates, or Recall (3 Light: a forgotten card returns to the discard)
3. **Steer**
   your second action. Either may be a Seek (once a turn) or a Push Through (once a game for each Ferryman)
4. **Soul Step**
   Lit and dry ahead: move. Otherwise: Linger
5. **Mist**
   turn one card of this Reach
6. **Settle and draw**
   roots drink the flood, trapped Grievances dissolve

Play a card

Face up
effect + knot + new Echo

Face down
1 Root only

Burn
effect ×2 + knot + new Echo; forget it + 1

Seek
discard 1, draw 1; no Resonance if it is your Answer

Push Through
Grievances on both banks ahead: they scatter and the soul steps forward; 1 Fracture (+1 per earlier push), forget 1; once a game for each Ferryman

Threads (4-5 knots)

Obsession
Backlash: Grievance beside the soul

Acceptance
Backlash: the soul Lingers

Oblivion
Backlash: Black Water ahead. Played cards are forgotten

Roots must touch

The soul's space or the next one, the opposite bank, or the same bank next door.

Forgetting

6
Light as Ash: glide +1

9
Adrift: drift into the dark, +1 Fracture

9-14
Faded: the game is lost

Lose if

Faded (9-14 forgotten) · **Shattered** (3 Fractures) · **Deluge** (water must rise, none left)

Icons

- Bloom
- Root
- Grievance
- Black Water
- Fog
- Stony
- Memory Site
- Grave
- Fracture
- Light
- Echo
- Blessing

Tokens

- Oar: whose turn
- Push Through: 1 each
- Hold Fast
- Shield
- Resignation

Discard pile face down; forgotten pile face up.